

PART VIII

The Kurdish situation in Turkey



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THE RISE OF THE PRO-KURDISH DEMOCRATIC MOVEMENT IN TURKEY

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The political representation of the Kurds in Turkey has been a problematic issue ever since the foundation of the republic in 1923. The main barrier to Kurdish representation in Turkey stemmed from the fact that the Kurds are not recognised as a separate national group, and to claim or advocate the separate existence of a Kurdish nation in Turkey is interpreted as a threat to Turkey's national security, territorial integrity and unity of the nation. As a result, the articulation of Kurdish political demands or rights was criminalised, and individuals and political parties that demanded group-specific rights for the Kurds were prosecuted. With the establishment of the People's Labour Party (HEP) in 1990, the representation of Kurdish interests has taken a more organised form. Due to the nature of the political demands they have been raising – such as the constitutional recognition of Kurdish identity – and the institutional legal limitations in Turkey, they have been considered as 'outsiders'. Consequently, they have been subjected to numerous suppressive practices, broadly speaking, on the basis that they promote Kurdish separatism, and the following parties have been banned: the HEP in 1993, the Democracy Party (DEP) in 1994, the People's Democracy Party (HADEP) in 2003 and the Democratic Society Party (DTP) in 2009. In the past decade, the pro-Kurdish political parties Peace and Democracy Party (BDP) and Peoples' Democratic Party (HDP) have increased their influence and power in the local and national levels. The transformation in the Kurdish conflict since 1999 and the democratisation reforms carried out as part of Turkey's EU accession process throughout the 2000s have increased the political space for the pro-Kurdish political parties to participate in politics and become important political actors. However, Turkey's descent into authoritarianism in the past two years has undone the progress of the pro-Kurdish democratic movement and resulted in its increased repression, which is ongoing at the time of writing.

This chapter discusses the rise of the pro-Kurdish movement since 1990 and what factors have enabled its success in a number of local and national elections since 2014. I first provide an account of the organisational development and growth of the movement from its foundation in 1990 to end of 2012 when the current pro-Kurdish political party the HDP was established. This section also broadly discusses the political demands raised by the pro-Kurdish parties and their proposals to reform the existing political framework to recognise ethnic and cultural identities and difference in Turkey, and examines the attempts by the pro-Kurdish political parties to build a greater coalition of pro-democracy forces. The second section

discusses the formation of the HDP and highlights the key political demands it articulates and its notions of democracy and pluralism. The final section discusses the factors behind the HDP's electoral breakthrough in the 2015 general elections.

The origins of the pro-Kurdish democratic movement

The pro-Kurdish democratic movement came into existence with the establishment of the HEP on 7 June 1990. The HEP was established by the Kurdish and socialist MPs who were expelled from the Social Democratic Populist Party (SHP) for attending an international conference on the Kurdish question held in Paris in September 1989. The expulsion of MPs created turmoil in the SHP, with six other MPs and the local leaders of the 12 party branches in the majority Kurdish cities resigning from the party in protest.¹ Although, Kurdish MPs and other leading Kurdish activists constituted the majority of the HEP's members, many Turkish socialist politicians, including Aydın Güven Gürkan, Abdullah Baştürk, Cüneyt Canver, Fehmi Işıklar and Arif Sağ (popular musician and a leading Alevi community leader) also took a leading role in its activities.²

The HEP had two combined objectives: the democratisation of the state and society, and formulating a democratic and peaceful solution to the Kurdish conflict in Turkey.³ In the parliamentary elections held on 20 October 1991, the HEP and SHP cooperated with the HEP candidates contesting the elections on the SHP's list, 22 of whom won a seat in the parliament. The election of 22 pro-Kurdish MPs was a unique event in the history of Turkey because it was the first time the representatives of a party committed to the recognition of Kurdish rights and demands were in Turkey's parliament. Throughout its existence the HEP remained committed to extending its appeal to the wider Turkish society and become a party for the whole of Turkey.⁴

However, it did not take long before state authorities began scrutinising the HEP's activities. On 22 May 1992, the state Security Court prepared a case for stripping the HEP MP's parliamentary immunity in order to prepare a court case against them. On 3 July 1992, the Supreme Court's Attorney General filed a case at the Constitutional Court to close down the HEP, and on 14 July 1993 it was closed down. To prolong the existence of the pro-Kurdish parliamentary opposition and thwart the dangers that the closure of the HEP would create, the Democracy Party (DEP) was established on 7 May 1993. Similar to the HEP, the DEP's political programme had the democratisation of the state and society as its principal objective. Specifically, it proposed a peaceful and democratic solution to the Kurdish question and comprehensive constitutional reform to enable Turkey to institute a pluralist democratic regime.⁵

The Turkish government and the security establishment described both the HEP and the DEP as the 'political wing' of the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK). This meant that the repression of the pro-Kurdish movement was done with relatively little domestic opposition. Throughout the early 1990s numerous Kurdish activists connected with the pro-Kurdish political parties were persecuted, including the frequent arrests and torture of many activists, and the murder of some leading members and many grass-roots activists. Between 1991 and 1994 more than 50 members of the HEP and the DEP were murdered. The DEP's headquarters were bombed on 18 Feb 1994, which caused the death of one person and the injury of 16 people.⁶ On 2 March 1994, the parliament lifted the legal immunity of the DEP MPs, which enabled the State Security Court in Ankara to hear the case against them. The DEP was closed down on 16 June 1994. The reasons listed by the constitutional court for the closures of HEP and DEP included claiming the existence of the Kurds as a separate national entity in Turkey, advocating their rights such as education in the Kurdish language and claiming

that they were persecuted or subjected to forced assimilation.⁷ The trial ended on 8 August 1994, with MPs Hatip Dicle, Orhan Doğan, Leyla Zana and Selim Sadak receiving 15-year sentences. In addition, six DEP MPs left Turkey in order to avoid imprisonment.

The next decade or so following the closure of the DEP and the elimination of the Kurdish parliamentary opposition was spent attempting to rebuild the pro-Kurdish democratic movement. The HADEP, established on 11 May 1994, and its sister party the Democratic People's Party (DEHAP), established on 24 October 1997, were the representatives of the pro-Kurdish movement in that period. Due to the 10 per cent national election threshold restricting the parliamentary representation, neither the HADEP nor the DEHAP was able to gain a seat in parliament. However, they both enjoyed some level of success at the local level and more importantly managed to construct a grass-roots organisation and a wide ranging organisational network covering many of the cities in Turkey. The HADEP obtained 4.76 per cent and 3.82 per cent in the parliamentary and municipal elections held in 1999, respectively. In total, it managed to win the control of 37 towns and cities across the majority Kurdish regions, including the municipal councils of Ağrı, Batman, Diyarbakır, Hakkari, Siirt and Van. In the 2004 municipal elections, the DEHAP increased the number of the councils it held to 54, including the municipality councils of Batman, Diyarbakır, Hakkari, Şırnak and Tunceli.⁸

Throughout its existence, one of the key difficulties for the pro-Kurdish democratic movement has been the dominant perception in Turkey that they are a party for the Kurds and the political wing of the PKK. There are similarities between the political demands the two movements articulate and both movements draw from the same social base. It is impossible to establish with certainty the extent of the assumed and popularly believed connection, but the implications for the pro-Kurdish political movement have been massive. It meant that from the onset it found itself in an uneasy position whereby it had to balance the articulation of popular Kurdish political demands with being a legal political party working within the existing constitutional framework, which considered the expression of such demands as a crime and unacceptable. Being the focal point of Kurdish activism reinforced the view in Turkey that the pro-Kurdish democratic movement was solely for the Kurds and the socialist members who were not comfortable with the predominance of the Kurds or with the fact that the solution to the Kurdish conflict was one of the main issues that it campaigned on left the movement. In addition, a number of events, such as the pulling down of a Turkish flag during the second congress of the HADEP held in Ankara on 23 June 1996 and the organisation of a hunger strike to protest against PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan's arrest in Rome in 1998, caused a furore in Turkey and reinforced the view that the pro-Kurdish movement was an extension of the PKK.⁹

While the case to close down the DEHAP was being considered by the constitutional court, the formation of a new pro-Kurdish political party was on the agenda.¹⁰ The DTP was formally established on 9 November 2005. Although the personnel of the party included many members of the former pro-Kurdish political parties in Turkey and it certainly represented the pro-Kurdish tradition in Turkey, it was established to represent broader sections of the society and attract other political groups in Turkey that its predecessors were unable to connect with.¹¹ After the 22 July 2007 general election, the pro-Kurdish parliamentary opposition returned with the election of 21 DTP MPs who stood as independent candidates in order to avoid the 10 per cent national election threshold. The DTP remained active until it was closed down by the Constitutional Court on 12 December 2009.

From then onwards, the BDP, which was established on 3 May 2008, took the task of Kurdish representation in Turkey. In April 2011, the BDP in alliance with 17 other

political parties and non-governmental organisations formed the pro-democracy ‘the Labour, Peace and Democracy Block’ and supported independent candidates in the general elections scheduled for 12 June 2011. In addition to the leading members of the pro-Kurdish BDP, independent socialist and pro-democracy candidates were also included in the list, including the film director and columnist Sırrı Süreyya Önder for Istanbul, the leader of the Labour Party (EMEP) Abdullah Levent Tüzel for Istanbul and the socialist activist and journalist Ertuğrul Kürkçü for Mersin. Broad democratic demands, such as gender equality, better working conditions, comprehensive constitutional reform and political reconciliation, were the key demands articulated in the election campaigns. In total 35 pro-Kurdish MPs were elected as independent candidates. Bringing together Turkey’s progressive opposition groups, including the socialist, pro-Kurdish and feminist movements, has long been the aim of Turkey’s pro-Kurdish political movement, and steps were taken to form a political party that could be the vehicle to achieve the left’s unity, which ultimately led to the HDP’s establishment.

The formation of the HDP

The HDP was founded to bring together various political movements, parties and civil society organisations that represent different social and minority ethnic and religious groups in Turkey. It was a new attempt to build a stronger, pro-democracy, left-wing alternative to the existing mainstream parties in Turkey. The approach the pro-Kurdish parties took during the 1990s and early 2000s was to participate in elections within an electoral coalition with other left-wing and opposition political parties with the aim of constructing a wider democratic bloc. Such an approach indeed enabled the pro-Kurdish parties to build a wider political network and broaden its appeal and membership during the late 2000s and early 2010s as more political groups and actors became incorporated into its structures. Crucially, however, this approach fell short of forging a stronger unity among the different groups within the left in Turkey. As a way to overcome this difficulty and as a precursor to the HDP foundation, the Peoples’ Democratic Congress (HDK) was established as a representative body for the diverse oppositional social and political groups and parties in Turkey. The initial idea for the establishment of the HDK came from the PKK’s jailed leader Abdullah Öcalan and was suggested for overcoming the impasse and repetition experienced within the left in Turkey. Öcalan’s endorsement was significant because it meant that the PKK and its followers supported the HDP’s establishment and the political project it set out to build in Turkey.

Each political group or party that is part of the HDK is described as a component and maintains its independent existence. The HDP is the national-level parliamentary representative of the HDK, and in the Kurdish majority regions at the local level the Democratic Regions Party (DBP) is active, which is the continuation of the BDP, having changed its name and party symbol at the third congress on 11 July 2014, and one of the main components of the HDK. In addition, the EMEP; the Socialist Party of the Oppressed; the Green Left Party; and numerous organisations that represent women, the Alevi community, the Armenian community, the Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, and Transgender (LGBT) community and workers also participated in the establishment of the HDK. The non-hierarchical organisational structure of the HDK is seen as essential for ensuring that each of the components as well as the communities that have been marginalised in Turkey are able to participate in politics. Such a structure does not subordinate individual struggles for democracy and equality to one another but unites them as part of a wider counter-hegemonic block for democracy and equality in Turkey.

In terms of membership and the personnel holding its executive positions, the HDP has become more diverse and in addition to the members and activists of the aforementioned groups and political parties it has also attracted members from the independent Turkish socialist and feminist activists. In the main cities in Turkey's west, such as Istanbul and Izmir, the HDP is also quite popular among the university students and urban intelligentsia from the more affluent districts and neighbourhoods. The HDP has a wide organisational network that covers all provinces, and it has separate youth and women branches. The HDP's key political objective is to represent the demands of the section of the society that have been historically marginalised by the state and ignored by the mainstream political parties, which is expressed in the party programme in the following way:

We are a party for Turkey's working classes, labourers, peasants, trades people, pensioners, women, youth, intellectuals, artists, LGBT individuals, the disabled, the oppressed and the exploited of all nations, languages, cultures and faiths who joined forces to reach the goal of moving towards establishing people's democratic power and government.¹²

While the HDP aspires to bring about political change via parliamentary politics and constitutional change, it also advocates a form of participatory democracy:

The HDP does not perceive democracy within the limits of representative democracy. It defends and struggles to realise the removal of barriers preventing citizens from debating, organising and directly participating in the decision-making mechanisms, to establish public scrutiny on all levels and the public's right to express its will and make decisions.¹³

A new democratic constitution that strengthens the parliamentary system and guarantees the civil and political rights of citizens in Turkey is another key demand raised by the HDP. The new constitution should embody the ethos of pluralism and promote multiculturalism by recognising and protecting Turkey's ethnic, linguistic and religious diversity. At the same time the new constitution should incorporate features to resolve Turkey's long-standing Kurdish question and provide stronger safeguards for the rights of all minority groups in Turkey. The HDP proposes a decentralised political system for Turkey to break the domination of the centre over the regions and develop models of local self-governance to meet the needs of different minority groups to protect and develop their culture and identity. More specifically, it advocates the 'Democratic Autonomy' model for Turkey and proposes to decentralise power to autonomous and self-governing local and regional administrations.¹⁴ Such decentralisation of the state in Turkey is needed to empower local administrations, ensure citizens' direct participation in the decision-making processes at the local, regional and national levels and to develop socio-economic policies that address the needs of the whole of society.

Such a decentralised and democratic framework can address the demands of the Kurdish minority for autonomy and pave the way to a peaceful solution for the Kurdish conflict:

Our party believes that a fundamental solution to all identity and cultural problems is possible with the adoption of a new democratic and pluralistic constitution that promotes freedom and equality. Our party struggles for the realisation of the constitutional assurance of equality of rights of different identities, languages, beliefs and cultures, and the definition of a constitutional citizenship shaped on this understanding; education

in mother tongue and the application of the right of using mother tongue in every area of life including the public sphere; and democratic autonomy operating on the basis of local self-governance.¹⁵

In addition to the accommodation of popular Kurdish political demands in order to resolve the Kurdish conflict, such as the provision of education in the Kurdish language, the HDP calls for a widespread programme to achieve societal reconciliation and address the consequences of widespread state-sanctioned violence against civilians over the course of the conflict, including addressing the needs of the forcibly displaced Kurdish people as a result of the state's counter-insurgency operations during the 1990s.

The HDP also campaigns for Alevi-specific demands such as removing compulsory religious education from the national curriculum and officially recognising *Cemevis* (Alevi assembly houses) as places of worship. Instead of the strict application of republican laicism, it advocates the full separation of the state and religion and calls for rebuilding the relationship between the state and religious authorities according to a new model of *laïcité* that is pro-diversity and protects freedom of religion. It advocates the abolishment of Turkey's Religious Affairs Directorate on grounds that existence of such an institution leads to the domination of religion by the state. As mentioned earlier, the HDP puts strong emphasis on gender equality in its party programme, election manifesto and statements that its representatives make to the media. Furthermore, it calls for the application of positive discrimination to achieve gender equality in political representation and proposes to apply the co-presidency system to all the elected political positions in Turkey to promote the representation of women in public life.

The HDP is one of the consultative parties of the Socialist International and sees itself as part of an international alliance of progressive democratic forces. Rather than having the goal of creating a socialist economic system, as was the case with Turkey's socialist movement, the economic policies it advocates have a reformist orientation and aim to increase economic equality and eliminate absolute poverty in Turkey. Hence, demands for improving the working conditions and ensuring the health and safety standards at work are met by employers, ending insecure employment and the widespread practice of subcontracting, combating attempts at deunionisation and ending practices that prevent new workers from becoming trade union members. Also measures to empower workers, such as collective bargaining rights and the right to strike, and increasing the minimum wage to a level sufficient for individuals and families to meet their needs, are demanded.

Measures to increase women's employment opportunities and end child-labour are also advocated and seen as an essential step to address the deep-rooted forms of inequality. Bringing an end to widespread privatisation of state-held enterprises and assets, and commercialisation of public services is also emphasised in the party programme and the election manifesto. A comprehensive welfare state in Turkey is also proposed that would involve providing social security to all citizens. In addition, improving educational and employment opportunities for the youth, such as more vocational and on-the-job training facilities, and improving the living conditions of disabled people, are also included in the HDP's economic policies as are specific measures to encourage job creation and developing agriculture. A progressive taxation system and encouraging social enterprises such as cooperatives are also part of the HDP's economic policy. The HDP's socio-economic programme is framed around building a fairer economic system that addresses the needs of workers and ensures the country's natural resources are used for the benefit of the whole society and in a way that protects the environment. Overall, the HDP has managed to construct a more condensed democratic

discourse that can appeal to a broader section of Turkey's population and is reflective of their demands and values.¹⁶

The HDP's breakthrough in the June 2015 election

Judged by the electoral performance of its predecessors, the HDP's success is unprecedented in the history of Turkish democracy. The HDP draws from the experience and resources of the pro-Kurdish movement as well as the other left-wing and Alevi social and community organisations. As a result it was able to exploit the synergies among these movements and mobilise a significantly larger section of the voters. By choosing parliamentary candidates from a wider network and among the representatives of diverse political, social and cultural groups, the HDP managed to connect with a much larger portion of the electorate, win their support and establish itself as the voice of the left in Turkey. Overall, the HDP's support increased across Turkey, but the increase was higher in the traditional heartlands of the pro-Kurdish movement in the east and south-east regions of the country and in the big cities in the west of Turkey that have a significant Kurdish population.

Slightly more than half of the HDP's 6 million votes came from the majority Kurdish provinces of the east and south-east regions of Turkey. The HDP obtained 636,915 votes in Diyarbakır, 368,516 votes in Van, 276,920 votes in Mardin, 191,309 votes in Batman, 188,002 votes in Şırnak, 185,506 votes in Ağrı, 137,878 votes in Muş, 122,807 votes in Hakkari, 93,513 votes in Siirt, 93,263 votes in Bitlis, 64,315 votes in Kars, 53,844 votes in Iğdır and 32,241 votes in Tunceli.¹⁷ As summarised later, the pro-Kurdish political parties had performed strongly in these provinces for more than a decade, but the HDP increased its share of the vote significantly, and in the case of the provinces of Hakkari and Şırnak, it managed to gain 86.4 per cent and 85.36 per cent of the vote respectively (Figure 19.1).

The HDP also performed strongly and came second in the Kurdish majority provinces of Şanlıurfa, Adıyaman and Bingöl, where it obtained 293,841, 69,513 and 53,519 votes, respectively. Also there was a surge in support for the HDP in Istanbul where it gained

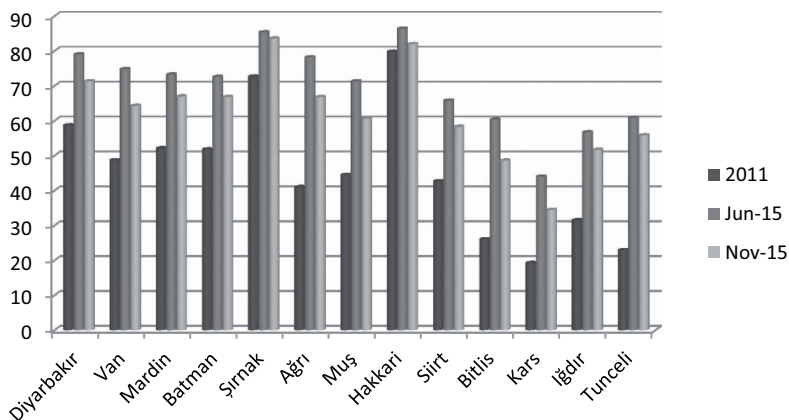


Figure 19.1 Percentage of votes the pro-Kurdish independent candidates obtained in the 2011 election and the percentage of votes the HDP obtained in the June 2015 and November 2015 elections in the Kurdish majority eastern and south-eastern provinces of Turkey.

Source: Compiled by author using Secim.Haberler.com (2015) 'Seçim Sonuçları' (<https://secim.haberler.com/>) (Accessed 15 September 2017).

1,030,761 votes to become the third party in the province and win 11 seats in the parliament. It performed well in Turkey's other provinces in the south and west of the country too. It gained 273,089 votes in Izmir, 183,934 votes in Mersin, 177,359 votes in Adana, 167,634 votes in Ankara, 138,678 votes in Gaziantep, 90,644 votes in Antalya and 96,513 votes in Bursa. In the previous election the pro-Kurdish independent candidates were fielded in only provinces where they had a realistic chance of winning. In contrast, participating in the elections as a party meant that the HDP fielded candidates in all of the provinces and gave its supporters across Turkey a chance to vote for its candidates. Also, the HDP ran a successful campaign abroad, especially in European countries that have a significant Kurdish and Turkish population and obtained 211,299 votes that were distributed among all the provinces (Figure 19.2).

A detailed report of the 7 June 2015 election results were provided by the Istanbul-based research consultancy company KONDA, and according to the report, the Kurds are the main supporters of the HDP and they make as much as 87 per cent of its voters (this figure includes the Zazas, who are generally considered to be another Kurdish ethnic group in Turkey but often counted separately). Only 9 per cent of the HDP voters are defined as Turkish, 1 per cent are estimated to be of Arab origin and in the case of 3 per cent of voters their ethnic background was not classified. Also, the report describes 87 per cent of the HDP voters as Sunni Muslims and only 7 per cent are estimated as Alevis.¹⁸

On a broader level, the transformation in Turkey's Kurdish conflict during the 2000s and the country's EU accession process since 2005 can be singled out as two most important developments that facilitated the HDP's rise in Turkish politics.¹⁹ The legal reforms the government carried out to meet the EU accession conditions have increased the democratic space for the pro-Kurdish political movement that it used to broaden its activities and become a more effective political actor. Reforms carried out in the subsequent years, such as in the area of Kurdish language broadcasting and tuition, enhanced the legitimacy of Kurdish demands in Turkey. The reform of the Associations Law (Law no.5253) in November 2004) also had a significant impact on Kurdish politics in Turkey as it made it

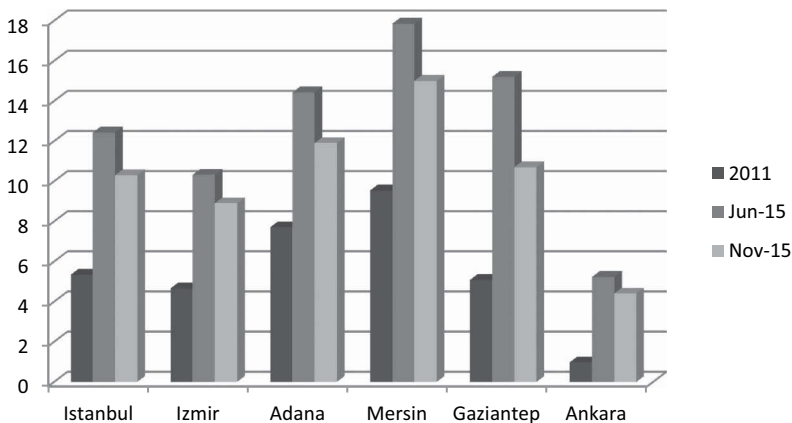


Figure 19.2 Percentage of votes the pro-Kurdish candidates obtained in the 2011 election and the percentage of votes the HDP obtained in the 7 June 2015 and 1 November 2015 elections in the western and southern provinces of Turkey.

Source: Compiled by author using Secim.Haberler.com (2015) 'Seçim Sonuçları' (<https://secim.haberler.com/>) (Accessed 15 September 2017).

easier to establish and manage charitable associations and in the subsequent decade led to a significant increase in the number of associations that were active in the Kurdish majority region of Turkey. This development facilitated the spread of democratic values and norms within the society and provided more avenues for Kurds to participate in politics and represent their interests.

The transformation of the conflict in the past two decades is also a significant factor in the rise of the HDP. The past two decades witnessed a significant reduction in the violent incidents between the PKK and the state security forces in Turkey, and although the violence returned after 2004, its intensity was far less than the violence of the 1990s. This transformation in the conflict created space for the pro-Kurdish political parties to promote reconciliation and a democratic solution to the Kurdish question. Their efforts received a significant impetus with the return of Kurdish representation to parliament in 2007. In the municipal elections held on 29 March 2009, the then pro-Kurdish DTP consolidated its position as the leading party of the Kurdish regions. Being represented in the national assembly and having the experience of running many of the local authorities in the majority Kurdish regions had enabled the pro-Kurdish movement to establish a strong regional and national presence. This allowed for the establishment and sustenance of links with various other social and political groups and foster better understanding and more cooperative relations between the different pro-democracy political groups in Turkey.

The HDP also played a key role in facilitating the communication between the state representatives and the PKK during the dialogue process that lasted from January 2013 to April 2015. The dialogue process involved regular meetings between government representatives, the HDP delegation, the jailed PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan and the PKK representatives, and produced some milestones, such as the ceasefire from March 2013 to July 2015 and a 10-point route map for the future negotiations that was made public on 28 February 2015 jointly by a HDP delegation and government representatives in Istanbul's Dolmabahçe Palace. Throughout the dialogue process, the HDP MPs involved in the dialogue process and its leaders had the opportunity to address the mainstream media, which gave more visibility to the HDP and provided it an opportunity to disseminate its political discourse to a much larger audience. Being one of the central actors of the dialogue process allowed the HDP to be seen by a greater number of people as a legitimate actor working towards the good of the whole of Turkish society. The performance of the HDP's co-leader Selahattin Demirtaş is another factor that needs to be highlighted. Demirtaş was a candidate in the presidential elections in August 2014 and subsequently became the public face of the HDP. The presidential election campaign gave Demirtaş and the HDP more visibility in the media and enabled them to reach out to a larger section of the society and disseminate the HDP's message across Turkey. Demirtaş proved to be a very strong media performer, and his confident and calm approach has won much praise.

The election strategy that the HDP followed also significantly contributed to its success. In western Turkey it selected candidates that represent and appeal to different sections of society and political movements. In Western Turkey, the HDP had a number of Alevi community leaders such as Turgut Öker and Ali Kenanoğlu in Istanbul, and Müslüm Doğan in Izmir. Well-known socialist activists, such as Ertuğrul Kürkçü and Sırrı Süreyya Önder, have been part of the HDP from the beginning and stood as candidates for Izmir and Ankara, respectively. Feminist activist Filiz Kerestecioğlu, Armenian rights activist Garo Paylan and Islamic feminist writer and journalist Hüda Kaya stood as candidates in Istanbul.

In the Kurdish majority areas, the HDP also incorporated candidates that would appeal to religious and tribal Kurds, such as Altan Tan for Diyarbakır and Mehmet Mir Dengir

Firat for Mersin, both of whom were active in Islamist-leaning political parties before. Nimettullah Erdoğan, who was the mufti of Diyarbakır, and Abdullah Zeydan, who is a member of the leading family of the Pinyanişi tribe, were selected as candidates for the Diyarbakır and Hakkari provinces, respectively. Similarly, Mahmut Celadet Gaydalı who is from the Gaydalı-İnan family that dominated the politics of Bitlis since the 1950s was selected for the Bitlis province. Another experienced politician changing his allegiance to the HDP in 2015 is Celal Doğan, who was previously active in the SHP and CHP was the mayor of Gaziantep province between 1989 and 2004. Additionally, candidates that could appeal to specific minorities such as the Arabs in Şanlıurfa and Mardin provinces were chosen as HDP parliamentary candidates. Consequently, by including diverse candidates, the HDP successfully mobilised a larger section of Turkey's population and managed to win votes from religious and tribal Kurds, ethnic Turks and Turkey's other ethnic or religious minorities.

Conclusion: the return of the state repression

The HDP thrived in the peaceful environment, and its political activism in the past four years has contributed to the shift in the public debate on the accommodation of Kurdish demands in Turkey. Many people in Turkey hoped that the success of the HDP in the June 2015 election would boost Turkey's search for peace and pave the way towards a negotiated end to the conflict with the PKK. However, the worsening security situation in Turkey and the Kurdish-majority regions since July 2015 presents major hurdles for the HDP's attempt to consolidate its gains and continue its growth as a political party. The intensification of violence in the conflict between the PKK and the state security forces in Turkey's majority Kurdish regions from summer 2015 onwards has led to an increase in instances of violent attacks by Turkish nationalists against the HDP. The anti-HDP fervour reached its height on 8 September 2015 when large-scale mob attacks targeted and vandalised the HDP's offices in many cities in western Turkey, including its headquarters in Ankara and many of the district offices in Istanbul. The IS (Islamic State) terror attacks targeting the HDP election rallies and those targeting Turkey's pro-Kurdish peace network in Suruç and Ankara, on 20 July 2015 and 10 October 2015, respectively, made running a campaign for the repeated November election very difficult for the HDP. As a result, there was a reduction in the HDP's vote in the November election, but despite that it still managed to obtain 5.15 million votes to win 10.75 per cent of the popular vote and 59 seats in the parliament.

The HDP is targeted because it is one of the main centres of opposition to the AKP's authoritarianism and the centralisation of power in the hands of Erdoğan. The AKP sees the HDP as a barrier to its objective of designing Turkish society in its Islamic conservative and Turkish nationalist image, and its accommodation of the Kurds is within the framework of Islamic unity.²⁰ The government aims to destroy the institutional base the HDP has managed to construct at the local and national levels. The oppressive practices that the state used to suppress the previous pro-Kurdish political parties during the 1990s and 2000s seem to have been reactivated once again against the HDP.

On 20 May 2016, the Turkish parliament passed legislation to lift the immunity of MPs, which is a measure designed by the government to end or at least significantly weaken the HDP representation in Turkey's parliament.²¹ Legal proceedings have already begun against a number of HDP deputies, including its co-presidents of the party Selahattin Demirtaş and Figen Yüksekdağ. The government passed a decree on 1 September 2016 to remove the elected pro-Kurdish mayors and replace them with appointed trustees. Currently 85

mayors of provinces and districts from its sister party the DBP are under arrest. Following the lifting of parliamentarian's immunity from prosecution in May 2016, many of the HDP MPs have been detained, and currently 10 remain under arrest, including the co-presidents of the party Selahattin Demirtaş and Figen Yüksekdağ. The MPs and co-presidents are charged with offences ranging from 'carrying out propaganda for a terror organisation' to 'being a member of an armed terror organisation', and the prosecutors are demanding long sentences for all of them. In February 2017, the parliament removed the status of MP from Figen Yüksekdağ, and in May 2017 from Nursel Aydoğan because of jail sentences they received in court cases dating back to 2013 and 2011, respectively.²² This is not the first time Turkey has taken such measure to eliminate the pro-Kurdish political representation, but the sheer numbers involved mark this occasion of political repression as unique in Turkey's recent history.

Notes

- 1 A. Osman Ölmez (1995) *Türkiye Siyasetinde DEP Depremi* (The DEP Earthquake in Turkish Politics), Ankara, pp. 88–90.
- 2 Eyyüp Demir (2005) *Yasal Kürtler* (Legal Kurds), Istanbul, pp. 92–93.
- 3 Halkın Emek Partisi (HEP), *Program* (Date and place of publications not mentioned).
- 4 Ahmet Türk (1994) *DEP Savunması* (The DEP Defence), Ankara, p. 7; Eyyüp Demir, *Yasal Kürtler*, Istanbul 2005, p. 116.
- 5 Demokrasi Partisi (DEP), *Program*, p. 9 (Date and place of publication not mentioned).
- 6 Ölmez, *Türkiye Siyasetinde DEP Depremi*, p. 465.
- 7 Derya Bayır (2013) *Minorities and Nationalism in Turkish Law* (Farnham: Ashgate), pp. 191–192.
- 8 Cengiz Gunes (2012) *The Kurdish National Movement in Turkey: From Protest to Resistance*, London and New York: Routledge, p. 167.
- 9 Ibid., p. 166.
- 10 'Eski Deplilerden Demokratik Toplum Hareketi', *Hürriyet*, 22 Oct. 2004.
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- 13 HDP, *Büyük İnsanlık-Bizler Meclise* (Election Manifesto), Ankara 2015, p. 5 (author's translation).
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- 15 HDP, Parti Programı, www.hdp.org.tr/parti/parti-programi/8, (accessed 8 May 2017, author's translation).
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- 17 The figures presented here are collated from the website <http://secim.haberler.com/>.
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- 19 For a more detailed discussion, see Cengiz Gunes (2017) 'Turkey's new left', *New Left Review*, 107, pp. 9–30.
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- 21 The Guardian (201) 'Erdoğan lifts Turkish MPs' immunity in bid to kick out pro-Kurdish parties', Online www.theguardian.com/world/2016/jun/08/erdogan-lifts-turkish-mps-immunity-in-bid-to-kick-out-pro-kurdish-parties, (accessed 4 July 2017).
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